



I More Power to Nepal

The days of political uncertainty in Nepal are finally over. The leader of the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist Leninist) Madhav Nepal finally took the oath as the prime minister of the country. A veteran communist, Madhav won the support of 350 members in the 601-member Assembly. He would now be heading a rather shaky coalition of almost two dozen parties. The biggest threat to the new premier would come from his ideological cousin: the Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist) led by Prachanda that would sit in the opposition. It controls 238 members in the Constituent Assembly. Following the resignation of Prachanda early this month, there was a fear that the Maoists may go back to their violent means as they disrupted the meetings of the House. As the Maoists accused India of interfering in their country's affairs, India confined itself to the back channels. With Nepal taking over, India would have a reason to smile as strategists hope he will tread the middle path unlike his predecessor Prachanda under whose leadership Nepal had been dangerously flirting with China. The 56-year-old communist leader who played a significant role in the people's movement that led to the end of monarchy may just bring relief to a country ravaged by violence and poverty.

**MADHAV NEPAL
AFTER TAKING
OATH AS THE
PRIME MINISTER**

22

parties have agreed to form a coalition in Nepal headed by Madhav Nepal.

by Saurabh Shukla